SURVEY REPORT

Experiment 3

Survey Report on Emerging Trends in Low-Code Application Development

An examination of eight leading low-code platforms - what they offer today, and where each is headed as AI reshapes application development

Submitted by

Roll Number: 241401012

August 2026

1. Microsoft Power Apps (Power Platform)

Vendor	Microsoft Corporation
Category	Enterprise low-code platform, part of the Microsoft Power Platform
Core Data Layer	Microsoft Dataverse
Target Users	Citizen developers, business analysts and professional developers across Microsoft 365 / Azure organisations

Overview

Microsoft Power Apps is one of the most widely deployed low-code platforms in the world, largely because it ships as part of the Microsoft Power Platform alongside Power Automate, Power BI and Power Pages, and sits directly on top of Microsoft 365 and Azure. It offers two principal building modes: canvas apps, which give makers a blank, pixel-precise canvas to design screens and drag on controls, and model-driven apps, which are generated automatically from an underlying Dataverse data model and are better suited to complex, data-heavy business applications. Because Power Apps shares its data layer, security model and connectors with the rest of the Power Platform, an app built by a single business user can be extended later by professional developers without a rebuild.

Key Capabilities

- Canvas apps for fully custom, screen-by-screen UI design with over 700 pre-built connectors to external systems.
- Model-driven apps that auto-generate forms, views and navigation from the Dataverse schema.
- Deep integration with Power Automate for workflow automation and Power BI for embedded analytics.
- Role-based security, environment management and data loss prevention policies for enterprise governance.

Current Focus (2026)

Through its 2025-2026 monthly release cadence, Microsoft has embedded Microsoft 365 Copilot directly inside both model-driven and canvas apps, giving business users a persistent side-pane assistant that can summarise records, answer questions grounded in company data, and draft new app logic from a plain-language description. New "app skills" for data entry, data exploration, visualisation and summarisation are now generally available, and an AI-first app builder lets a maker describe an entire application in natural language and receive a working first draft. On the governance side, Microsoft has introduced advanced connector policies and a Power Apps MCP Server, giving administrators an "agent feed" through which they can supervise the actions that autonomous AI agents take inside business applications.

Future Trajectory

Microsoft's stated direction is to move Power Apps from a manually assembled canvas toward an agent-supervised environment, where makers increasingly describe the outcome they want while Copilot and autonomous agents assemble the underlying data model, business logic and interface. Expect deeper adoption of the Model Context Protocol so that external AI coding tools such as Cursor and Claude Code can build directly against Dataverse, closer ties between Power Pages and AI coding agents for external-facing sites, and continued expansion of the "agent feed" concept so that IT teams can audit and roll back AI-driven changes with the same confidence they have over human-made ones.

2. OutSystems

Vendor	OutSystems
Category	Enterprise high-productivity low-code / Agentic Systems Platform
Positioning	Mission-critical, large-scale application delivery
Target Users	Professional developers and IT-led delivery teams in regulated enterprises

Overview

OutSystems built its reputation on "high-productivity" application development for large, complex, mission-critical systems - the kind of software that traditional low-code tools were once considered too lightweight to handle. Its visual development environment compiles down to standard, readable code rather than an opaque runtime, which has historically made it attractive to enterprises that need both low-code speed and the auditability of hand-written software. Typical OutSystems customers include banks, insurers, airlines and government agencies running applications that must scale to millions of users while meeting strict compliance requirements.

Key Capabilities

- Visual, model-driven development that compiles to standard application code rather than a proprietary black box.
- One-click deployment, built-in DevOps pipelines and application lifecycle management for enterprise-scale rollouts.
- Pre-built connectors, reusable component libraries ("Forge") and integration with existing enterprise architecture.
- Enterprise-grade security, performance monitoring and scalability tooling out of the box.

Current Focus (2026)

At its 2026 ONE Conference, OutSystems rebranded itself around a new "Agentic Systems Platform" built on what it calls the Enterprise Context Graph. The company introduced Mentor, an AI pair-programmer that can generate application logic and agent workflows directly inside the platform, and Agent Workbench, a dedicated environment for managing the full lifecycle of AI agents - from creation through testing to production supervision. A new native integration with AWS's Kiro agentic development environment lets teams build and govern agents collaboratively across tools, and a Legacy Modernisation Service powered by AWS Transform offers an automated migration pipeline for ageing systems built on technologies such as COBOL and Lotus Notes.

Future Trajectory

OutSystems is positioning itself as an open, governed layer for enterprise AI rather than a platform locked to a single AI vendor. It is exposing Agent-to-Agent (A2A) and Model Context Protocol tool interfaces so that organisations can build, orchestrate and audit entire portfolios of AI agents while retaining control over which large language model powers each one - protecting customers from vendor lock-in. Expect continued investment in sovereign and regional cloud partnerships (starting with AWS, with other providers to follow) so that regulated industries can adopt agentic development without compromising on data residency or compliance obligations.

3. Mendix (a Siemens business)

Vendor	Mendix, owned by Siemens
Category	Enterprise low-code platform for industrial and digital-twin applications
Ecosystem Tie-In	Siemens Xcelerator industrial software portfolio
Target Users	Professional developers and citizen developers in manufacturing, industrial and enterprise IT teams

Overview

Mendix is a model-driven low-code platform that Siemens has folded into its broader Xcelerator industrial software strategy, giving it a distinctive footprint in manufacturing, IoT and digital-twin use cases that go beyond the typical office-productivity applications built on other low-code tools. It supports a full spectrum of contributors, from citizen developers using its more visual tooling to professional developers who work with Java and JavaScript extensions, all collaborating inside a single shared project.

Key Capabilities

- Visual, model-driven app modelling with a shared workspace for citizen and professional developers.
- Native integration with Siemens industrial software, IoT platforms and digital-twin tooling.
- Flexible deployment across Mendix Cloud, private cloud or on-premises infrastructure.
- An extensive marketplace of reusable modules, connectors and widgets.

Current Focus (2026)

Mendix's own 2025 retrospective describes a shift from merely "generating content" with AI to "executing logic" - its generative AI tooling now scaffolds data models, workflows and UI directly, while professional developers focus on the security, scalability and architectural detail that Mendix calls the "invisible ten percent" separating a working demo from production-grade software. This reflects a deliberate design choice: Mendix aims to give teams the speed of AI-generated applications without surrendering the governance and technical rigor that industrial and enterprise deployments demand.

Future Trajectory

Mendix's roadmap frames 2026 as the year of moving toward "ecosystems of agents" - multiple cooperating AI agents handling different parts of a workflow, with the developer acting as a conductor rather than a line-by-line coder. Siemens's backing suggests Mendix will keep extending this agentic capability specifically into industrial IoT and digital-twin scenarios, where AI agents might eventually monitor physical equipment through a digital twin and trigger or adjust low-code workflows automatically in response to real-world conditions.

4. Appian

Vendor	Appian Corporation (Nasdaq: APPN)
Category	Enterprise process automation and orchestration platform
Track Record	More than 25 years automating processes for large enterprises and governments
Target Users	Enterprise process owners, IT teams and regulated industries such as finance, insurance and government

Overview

Appian is built around the idea that business value comes from orchestrating end-to-end processes - not just building isolated screens. Its platform visualises how work actually moves through an organisation: the steps involved, how long each one takes, who or what is responsible, and where bottlenecks occur. On top of this process foundation, Appian layers low-code app-building tools, a unified data fabric that provides read-write access across disparate systems, and, increasingly, AI agents that can act as participants inside a governed process rather than as standalone chatbots.

Key Capabilities

- Visual process modelling that captures every step, actor and metric in a complex workflow.
- Data fabric providing unified, real-time read-write access to data spread across multiple back-end systems.
- Low-code app and interface builder layered directly on top of process definitions.
- Built-in case management, robotic process automation and business rules engines for regulated workflows.

Current Focus (2026)

At Appian World 2026, the company announced Appian Composer, an AI-assisted, spec-driven development tool that lets teams describe requirements conversationally and iteratively refine a generated application, and adopted the Model Context Protocol so that AI agents - both Appian's own and third-party agents - can interface securely with the data fabric and other enterprise systems. Appian has also partnered with Snowflake to connect its data fabric directly to Snowflake Cortex AI, and is developing the ability to track how well an AI agent performs over time so that its "memory" can be reapplied to improve future decisions.

Future Trajectory

Appian intends to move beyond agents that simply execute predefined steps toward agents that can be given a business objective and asked to recommend - and eventually safely apply - improvements to a live process on their own, always within the structure and guardrails that a defined process provides. This anchoring of AI "within process" is Appian's central bet: that enterprises will trust autonomous AI far more readily when its actions are constrained by an auditable workflow than when it operates as an open-ended chat agent.

5. Salesforce Platform (Lightning App Builder & Agentforce)

Vendor	Salesforce, Inc.
Category	CRM-embedded low-code platform with an agentic AI layer
Core Tools	Lightning App Builder, Flow Builder, Agentforce Builder
Target Users	Sales, service and marketing teams already operating on the Salesforce CRM

Overview

The Salesforce Platform lets organisations extend their CRM with custom pages, workflows and automations without leaving the Salesforce ecosystem. Lightning App Builder is a point-and-click tool for assembling custom pages, dashboards and navigation out of standard and custom components, while Flow Builder provides visual, drag-and-drop process automation. Increasingly, these low-code building blocks are being repositioned as the raw material for Agentforce, Salesforce's agentic AI layer, which can call Flows, Apex code and prompt templates as "tools" that an autonomous agent invokes to complete a task.

Key Capabilities

- Lightning App Builder for assembling custom record pages, home pages and app navigation without code.
- Flow Builder and Prediction Builder for visual process automation and AI-assisted predictions.
- Agentforce Builder for assembling and customising autonomous AI agents using existing Salesforce business logic.
- The AppExchange marketplace, offering thousands of pre-built components and integrations.

Current Focus (2026)

The Spring '26 release introduced the Agentforce Builder, which lets teams assemble AI agents using low-code tools, define the agent's tasks through natural-language "topics" and guidelines, and connect those tasks to existing Flows, Apex code, MuleSoft APIs and prompt templates - all without writing code. A beta "Setup with Agentforce" mode now lets administrators configure Lightning pages and platform settings using natural language, and a new Agentforce DX MCP Server allows agents to be wired into systems outside Salesforce in a governed way.

Future Trajectory

Salesforce's clear direction is to push Agentforce across the entire platform so that virtually every low-code asset an organisation has already built - a Flow, an Apex trigger, a prompt template - becomes a callable capability for an autonomous agent. Over time this blurs the distinction between "building an app" and "building a digital labour force": rather than a human clicking through screens built with Lightning App Builder, an Agentforce agent may complete much of that work itself, with the low-code assets serving as its trusted, auditable toolkit.

6. Zoho Creator

Vendor	Zoho Corporation
Category	SMB-focused low-code application platform
AI Assistant	Zia
Target Users	Small and mid-sized businesses seeking affordable, fast application development

Overview

Zoho Creator has built a large following among small and mid-sized businesses by offering rapid form-and-workflow application development at a fraction of the cost of enterprise low-code platforms, while still supporting mobile and web deployment out of the box. It integrates tightly with the wider Zoho One suite of business applications, so a Creator app can easily pull in data from Zoho's CRM, finance or HR products, and it uses a proprietary scripting language called Deluge for logic that goes beyond drag-and-drop configuration.

Key Capabilities

- Drag-and-drop form and workflow builder deployable simultaneously to web and mobile.
- Deluge scripting language for custom logic beyond what visual tools alone can express.
- Deep integration with the broader Zoho One suite of business applications.
- Enterprise security options including bring-your-own-key encryption and multi-factor authentication for portal users.

Current Focus (2026)

Zoho's recent Creator release cycle has centred on its Zia AI assistant, adding Zia-powered app creation that can scaffold forms and workflows from a description, AI assistance directly inside the Deluge scripting editor, a built-in QR-code and barcode generator, and new connectors that broaden the range of external systems a Creator app can talk to. Security has also advanced, with bring-your-own-key encryption at rest and multi-factor authentication specifically for external portal users, addressing a common gap in SMB-tier platforms.

Future Trajectory

Zoho is expected to keep pushing Zia-powered generation deeper into the build process, so that a short natural-language prompt increasingly produces a working form, workflow or report rather than just a starting template, while broadening integration across Zoho One so that Creator apps and Zoho's other business products behave as a single connected system. The company's central challenge is to keep pace with AI-native, prompt-to-app entrants without abandoning the low-cost, SMB-friendly positioning that differentiates it from heavier enterprise low-code platforms.

7. Google AppSheet

Vendor	Google (Google Cloud)
Category	No-code / low-code platform for spreadsheet- and database-driven apps
Common Data Sources	Google Sheets, Airtable, Excel, cloud SQL databases
Target Users	Google Workspace users and teams that already keep data in a spreadsheet or simple database

Overview

AppSheet takes a distinctive approach to app building: rather than starting from a blank canvas, it starts from data the user already has - typically a Google Sheet, an Airtable base or a simple cloud database - and generates a functioning mobile and web application directly from that schema. This makes it an unusually fast on-ramp for teams that already track information in spreadsheets and simply want a proper app interface, offline mobile access and automation layered on top, without needing to design a data model from scratch.

Key Capabilities

- Automatic app generation from an existing spreadsheet or database schema.
- Strong offline mobile support with automatic data synchronisation once connectivity returns.
- Built-in automation ("bots") for workflows such as notifications, approvals and scheduled actions.
- Deep, native integration with Google Workspace and Google Cloud services.

Current Focus (2026)

AppSheet remains firmly positioned inside the Google ecosystem and continues to be recognised particularly for its data-synchronisation and offline-mobile capabilities, which reviewers consistently rate above many competing no-code tools. Its AI-generated app templates and automation suggestions have improved, but the platform's visual customisation remains comparatively limited next to more design-flexible tools, and it still requires a pre-existing data source before an app can be built, which can be a barrier for teams starting from nothing.

Future Trajectory

The clearest trajectory for AppSheet is tighter integration with Google's Gemini models for natural-language app generation and automation authoring - letting a user describe a workflow in plain language and have AppSheet configure the underlying bots and logic automatically. Rather than competing head-on with heavyweight enterprise platforms, AppSheet is likely to keep doubling down on being the fastest possible on-ramp from "a spreadsheet full of data" to "a working app", for teams already living inside Google Workspace and Google Cloud.

8. Bubble.io

Vendor	Bubble Group
Category	No-code, full-stack visual platform for web and mobile applications
AI Feature	Bubble AI Agent (beta)
Target Users	Startup founders and product teams building customer-facing SaaS applications

Overview

Bubble is a fully visual, no-code platform capable of producing complete, full-stack web applications - front end, back end and database - from a single visual editor, with no code exported or required. It has become particularly popular among startup founders building early-stage SaaS products, marketplaces and internal tools, because a single non-technical builder can design the interface, define the data model and configure workflows entirely within Bubble, without hiring a developer for the first version of a product.

Key Capabilities

- Fully visual front-end, back-end and database design in a single unified editor.
- Native iOS and Android app output sharing a common backend with the web application.
- A large plugin marketplace covering payments, AI integrations, analytics and more.
- Workload-based pricing that scales with usage rather than a fixed per-seat cost.

Current Focus (2026)

Bubble's 2026 AI Agent (currently in beta) can create and edit user interfaces, data types and front-end workflows directly from natural-language prompts, troubleshoot problems using an automated issue checker, and explain how an existing app is built - effectively acting as a build partner inside the same visual editor rather than a separate code-generation tool. This lets founders combine prompt-driven speed with the ability to step back into the visual editor at any point to make precise manual changes, which is a key differentiator from AI tools that only generate code a user cannot easily edit.

Future Trajectory

Bubble's stated direction is to keep closing the gap between prompt-driven speed and full editability, continuing to invest in application performance, native mobile compilation and the capabilities of its AI Agent so that founders and product teams can move from an idea to a production-ready SaaS application without switching tools midway or being forced to export and maintain generated code themselves.

9. Market Landscape: What Is Driving This Growth

Industry estimates place the global low-code/no-code development platform market at roughly USD 60-65 billion in 2026, up from about USD 13 billion in 2020, and project it will approach USD 90-95 billion by 2028. This rapid growth, illustrated in Figure 1, reflects three structural forces that show up consistently across all eight platforms surveyed in this report.

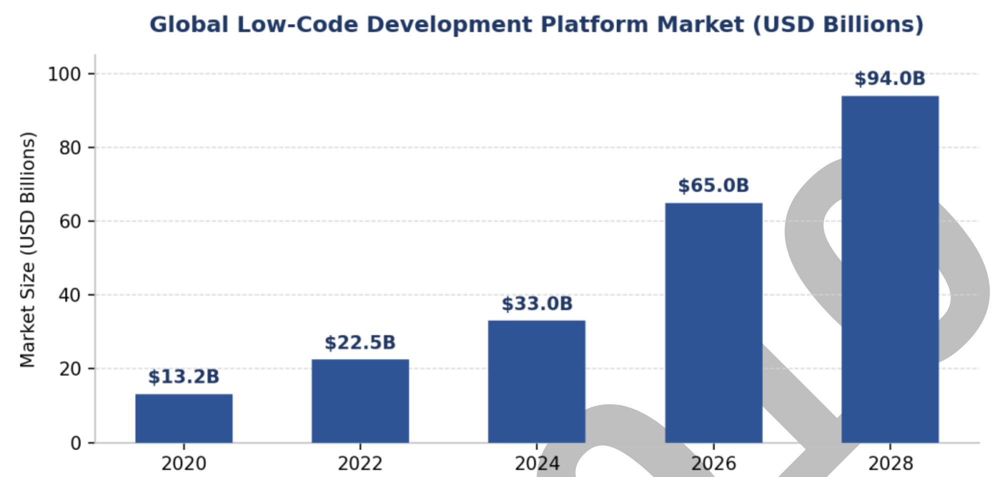

Figure 1: Approximate size of the global low-code development platform market, 2020-2028 (USD Billions).

Developer Scarcity

Organisations across every industry continue to face a persistent shortage of professional software developers relative to the volume of internal and customer-facing applications they want to build. Low-code and no-code tools extend the reach of a limited engineering workforce by letting existing staff assemble functional applications visually, dramatically shortening the path from an idea to a working tool without proportionally increasing headcount.

The Rise of Citizen Development

A large and growing share of low-code users today sit outside formal IT departments altogether. Analysts describe this as citizen development: business users in operations, sales and finance building their own departmental tools under guardrails that IT defines centrally, such as approved connectors, data-loss-prevention policies and environment separation. This has shifted low-code platforms from being simply developer-productivity tools to being genuine self-service platforms for the wider organisation.

Generative and Agentic AI

The single biggest change across the category in 2025-2026 has been the embedding of generative AI copilots, and increasingly autonomous AI agents, directly into the build and run experience of nearly every platform surveyed in this report. This has compressed the time from idea to working application even further, while also introducing new governance questions, such as how much autonomy an AI agent should have over production data, that vendors are now racing to answer through structured tool interfaces and audit trails.

10. Comparative Feature Matrix

The table below consolidates all eight platforms surveyed, positioning each by primary market segment, its headline AI capability as of 2026, and the type of team or project it is best suited to.

Table 1: Comparative overview of eight low-code platforms.

Platform	Primary Segment	Core 2026 AI Capability	Best Suited For
Microsoft Power Apps	Enterprise / Microsoft 365	Copilot-driven app skills & MCP agent feed	Enterprises on the Microsoft stack
OutSystems	Enterprise / mission-critical	Mentor + Agent Workbench (agentic systems)	Regulated, high-scale applications
Mendix	Enterprise / industrial	AI-assisted logic generation, agent ecosystems	Manufacturing & Siemens-linked IoT
Appian	Enterprise process automation	Composer spec-driven dev + MCP data fabric	Complex, regulated business processes
Salesforce Platform	CRM-embedded	Agentforce Builder & Agentforce DX MCP	Sales, service & marketing teams
Zoho Creator	SMB / mid-market	Zia AI app & Deluge code assistance	Cost-conscious SMB app teams
Google AppSheet	No-code / Workspace	Gemini-linked NL automation authoring	Google Workspace-centric teams
Bubble.io	No-code / full-stack SaaS	Bubble AI Agent for UI & workflow editing	Startups & founders building SaaS

Observed pattern: enterprise platforms (Power Apps, OutSystems, Mendix, Appian, Salesforce) are converging on agentic, MCP-based architectures that let AI agents act on governed data with audit trails, while SMB and no-code platforms (Zoho Creator, AppSheet, Bubble.io) are focused on making AI-assisted app generation faster and more accessible to non-technical builders.

A second pattern is that platform choice increasingly tracks organisational scale and risk tolerance rather than raw feature count alone: enterprises with regulatory exposure gravitate toward platforms with strong governance and audit capabilities, while startups and individual builders continue to favour the speed and low upfront cost of no-code platforms, even where those platforms offer less architectural control.

11. Evolution of the Low-Code Paradigm and What Comes Next

Across all eight platforms surveyed, the underlying build experience has evolved through four broad, overlapping stages - moving progressively from manual visual assembly toward AI systems that can plan and execute development tasks under human supervision.

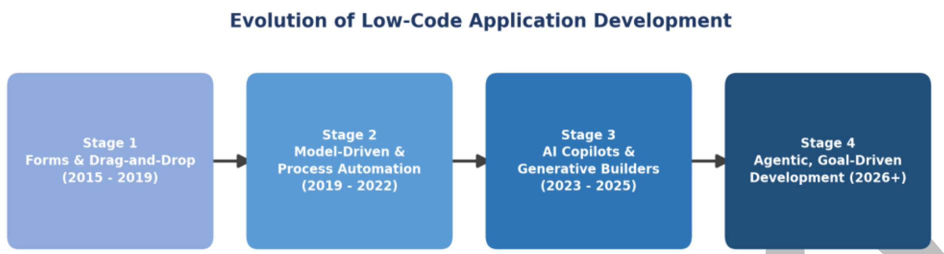

Figure 2: Four broad stages in the evolution of low-code application development.

Every platform surveyed in this report currently sits somewhere between Stage 3 (AI copilots and generative builders) and Stage 4 (agentic, goal-driven development). Enterprise vendors - OutSystems, Mendix, Appian and Microsoft - have moved furthest toward Stage 4, publishing explicit "agent workbench" or "agent orchestration" capabilities in 2026, while SMB and no-code vendors are still concentrating on making Stage 3 copilots more reliable and easier to use for non-technical builders.

Where the Category Is Headed

Analysts expect low-code platforms to move from conversational app generation - describe an app, get a working prototype - toward goal-driven agents that continuously build, test and refine workflows with limited human intervention. As AI agents gain the ability to read and write production data, platforms are racing to add MCP-based tool interfaces, audit trails and environment controls so that IT can set guardrails without slowing down business builders, closing the long-standing trade-off between low-code speed and governance.

Several enterprise vendors are also explicitly targeting legacy modernisation - for example, automated migration pipelines for COBOL and other ageing systems - positioning low-code platforms not only for new application development but as the delivery layer for replacing decades-old core systems. Industry forecasts anticipate that within a few years, a large majority of mission-critical enterprise applications will depend on low-code tooling in some form, reflecting a broader convergence of low-code development, robotic process automation and business process management into unified "composable enterprise" toolchains. At the same time, no-code and prosumer platforms such as Bubble.io and AppSheet continue to grow quickly among startups and individual builders, suggesting the market will keep serving both ends of the technical-skill spectrum rather than converging on a single tier of tool.